ORIGIN OF COLD WAR

It is an arduous task to trace the origin and development of Cold War. Young and Kent[2] point out that there had been innumerable debates regarding the nature and origin of the early Cold War which had a definite impact on the ways the historians and social scientists had interpreted the nature of international system, till 1989. The origin of Cold War still remains a matter of long-standing historical dispute.

The orthodox theories assume that the alleged Soviet aggression or Soviet expansionism resulted in American counter reactions. They opine that in essence the Cold War became a battle for global influence because Stalin and the Soviet system made cooperation impossible. For them, Stalin and Soviet Communism had to be confronted and contained by the Western capitalist states for the sake of international peace and security and the survival of the liberal democratic values. To be more specific, an allegedly expansionist Soviet Union threatened the 'national security' of the United States and the Western Europe which required an economic and military response. This can be viewed more or less as the realist or neo-realist perception of the superpower rivalry. In this perception, power and security as well as functioning of the capitalist and communist states and their respective external requirements figure more importantly rather than ideology or internal structure.

The orthodox view was challenged in the 1960s by the revisionist historians who focussed less on the international state system and the struggle to gain greater power and influence and more on the alleged requirements of international capitalism, especially of the United States in the 1940s. Revisionist interpretation laid emphasis on the foreign policy requirements of the United States, which they viewed was designed to meet the expansionist requirements of capitalism. The Soviets, therefore, sought security in the form of resisting expansion of capitalism into areas that would threaten the existence of Soviet Communism. Thus, for the revisionists, the blame for the Cold War lies with the aggressive US policies to which the Soviets had to respond. According to this perception, therefore,